

CENTRAL BOARD OF SECONDARY EDUCATION — PRACTICE EXAMINATION**CLASS IX • SOCIAL SCIENCE (SUBJECT CODE: 087) • ACADEMIC SESSION 2026-27****SET E — CASE STUDY & SOURCE-BASED SCENARIOS****CHAPTER 01: UNDERSTANDING SOCIAL SCIENCE**

TIME ALLOWED: 45 MINUTES

MAXIMUM MARKS: 25 MARKS

SERIES: CBS-IX-SST-SET-E-01

Student's Name: _____

Roll No.: _____

Class & Section: Class IX - _____

Date of Exam: _____

Invigilator's Sign: _____

General Instructions (SET E - Case Study & Source-Based Scenarios):

1. The question paper comprises **5 In-Depth Case Studies & Source Scenarios** with **5 MCQs each (Total: 25 Questions, 1 Mark each)**.
2. Read each source passage, historical inscription, geographic case, and economic scenario carefully before answering the corresponding questions.
3. Each question has 4 options with a single correct answer.
4. All questions are compulsory. There is no negative marking.
5. Darken the corresponding bubble on the **OMR Sheet** completely using a blue/black ballpoint pen.

CASE STUDY 1: ARCHAEOLOGICAL STRATIGRAPHY & EXCAVATION AT TAXILA

During archaeological investigations at the ancient university city of Taxila, excavations revealed multiple distinct cultural strata accumulated over more than a millennium. Sir John Marshall and later Sir Mortimer Wheeler conducted scientific digs applying the Law of Superposition. Stratum IV (the deepest layer) yielded Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW) alongside punch-marked silver coins. Stratum III contained Indo-Greek coins bearing bilingual Greek and Kharosthi inscriptions. Stratum II revealed Kushana gold dinaras and Gandharan schist stone sculptures, while Stratum I (the top layer) exhibited evidence of burning, debris, and White Hun (Huna) iron arrowheads dating to the late 5th century CE. Wheeler introduced the box-grid method, leaving vertical balks of undisturbed earth between square excavation trenches. These vertical balks enabled excavators to cross-correlate soil profiles and establish an unbroken timeline of settlement and destruction.

Q.1 According to the Law of Superposition applied at Taxila, which cultural layer is historically the oldest?

- | | |
|---|--|
| (A) Stratum I containing Huna arrowheads and ash | (B) Stratum II containing Kushana gold dinaras |
| (C) Stratum III containing Indo-Greek bilingual coins | (D) Stratum IV containing Northern Black Polished Ware |

Q.2 What was the primary scientific purpose of preserving vertical soil balks in Mortimer Wheeler's box-grid excavation method?

- | | |
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| (A) To build permanent stone walls for tourist pathways | (B) To maintain visible vertical stratigraphic profiles across adjoining trenches |
| (C) To prevent workers from uncovering metal coins too quickly | (D) To collect underground rainwater for washing pottery fragments |

Q.3 The discovery of bilingual inscriptions in Greek and Kharosthi in Stratum III demonstrates that ancient Taxila was:

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| (A) A totally isolated rural village with zero outside contact | (B) A cosmopolitan commercial and cultural crossroad connecting Hellenistic and Indian worlds |
| (C) An exclusively Roman colony governed from Mediterranean Italy | (D) An unpopulated wilderness used only as a seasonal pasture |

Q.4 The thick layer of ash, burnt debris, and iron arrowheads in Stratum I provides material evidence of:

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| (A) A peaceful religious pilgrimage festival | (B) Violent destruction and military assault by the White Huns (Hunas) |
| (C) A massive subterranean volcanic eruption | (D) An agricultural celebration marking the harvest |

Q.5 Why would an archaeologist categorize punch-marked coins found in Stratum IV as primary sources rather than secondary sources?

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| (A) They were produced by contemporary ancient authorities during the actual period under study | (B) They were manufactured in modern universities by professional researchers |
| (C) They were written in modern English printed textbooks | (D) They represent imaginative historical fiction novels |

CASE STUDY 2: DECIPHERING ANCIENT INSCRIPTIONS: JAMES PRINSEP & THE GIRNAR ROCK EDICTS

In 1837, James Prinsep, the founding secretary of the Asiatic Society of Bengal, achieved a breakthrough in Indian historiography by successfully deciphering the ancient Brahmi script. For centuries, rock edicts carved into granite boulders at Junagadh (Girnar) in Gujarat remained an indecipherable enigma. Local traditions attributed the inscriptions to legendary mythical kings. By meticulously cataloguing recurring phonetic characters on Indo-Greek coins that paired known Greek royal names with their Prakrit equivalents in Brahmi, Prinsep decoded the alphabet. Upon translating the Girnar rock edicts, he discovered that a ruler styling himself 'Devanampiya Piyadassi' (Beloved of the Gods, of pleasant countenance) had proclaimed decrees enjoining medical treatment for humans and animals, prohibiting animal slaughter, and urging obedience to parents and respect for ascetics. Subsequent discovery of the Maski and Gurjarra edicts confirmed that Piyadassi was none other than the Mauryan Emperor Ashoka.

Q.6 How did James Prinsep decipher the Brahmi script in 1837?

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| (A) By guessing the meaning through mythological folklore | (B) By comparing known Greek names with Prakrit Brahmi legends on bilingual Indo-Greek coins |
| (C) By consulting medieval Mughal court chronicles in Persian | (D) By using computer software algorithms to generate translations |

Q.7 The scientific discipline focused specifically on deciphering and interpreting inscribed texts on rocks, pillars, and metal plates is termed:

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|-----------------|----------------------|
| (A) Numismatics | (B) Epigraphy |
| (C) Palynology | (D) Dendrochronology |

Q.8 Why were the edicts of Ashoka inscribed on prominent public rock faces like Girnar?

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| (A) To hide royal secrets away from the common subjects | (B) To communicate moral codes (Dhamma) publicly to travelers and citizens along major trade routes |
| (C) To decorate mountain landscapes for aesthetic royal gardens | (D) To test the stone-cutting skills of local quarry workers |

Q.9 The confirmation that the title 'Devanampiya Piyadassi' referred to Ashoka was definitively corroborated when:

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| (A) Edicts at Maski and Gurjarra were discovered bearing the actual name 'Ashoka' | (B) A signed letter written on papyrus was recovered in Rome |
| (C) Modern newspapers reported the identity in 1947 | (D) Medieval British travelers wrote travelogues about the emperor |

Q.10 What ethical duties are emphasized in Ashoka's Girnar inscriptions as core components of Dhamma?

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| (A) Aggressive military conquest and enslavement of foreign populations | (B) Compulsory religious conversion and destruction of opposing sects |
| (C) Medical aid for humans and animals, non-violence, and filial respect | (D) Imposition of heavy land taxes and state monopolization of all grain |

CASE STUDY 3: NUMISMATIC SCIENCE & ECONOMIC HISTORY OF THE KUSHANA EMPIRE

Numismatics (the scientific study of coins) offers profound insights into the economic vitality, metallurgical technology, and geographic trade networks of ancient states. The Kushana emperors, notably Kanishka I and Huvishka (c. 1st–2nd centuries CE), issued vast quantities of high-purity gold coins called 'dinaras'. Metallurgical assays reveal that Kushana gold dinaras maintained a standard weight of approximately 8 grams with gold purity exceeding 98%. The abundance of Kushana gold coinage was directly linked to their strategic command over the Silk Route connecting Han China, India, and the Roman Empire. Roman historian Pliny the Elder lamented that the Roman Empire suffered a massive annual trade deficit of over 50 million sesterces flowing into India to purchase luxury silk, black pepper, and fine spices. However, under later 3rd-century Kushana rulers, metallurgical analysis shows that the gold content of dinaras dropped sharply to below 60%, replaced by base copper alloys. Economic historians interpret this debasement as empirical proof of declining silk route trade and fiscal distress.

Q.11 What direct economic insight does the 98% gold purity of early Kushana dinaras provide?

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| (A) The empire had a bankrupt economy and zero foreign commerce | (B) The empire enjoyed exceptional economic prosperity and robust international trade surpluses |
| (C) The empire had banned all agricultural farming activities | (D) The emperors did not know how to smelt copper or iron |

Q.12 Why was the Roman Empire exporting enormous quantities of gold and silver bullion to India during the Kushana period?

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| (A) To pay tribute to Indian monarchs who had militarily invaded Rome | (B) To settle trade deficits arising from the import of Indian spices, pepper, and fine textiles |
| (C) To construct Roman Catholic churches in North India | (D) To purchase Indian iron weapons for the Roman gladiators |

Q.13 What does a significant debasement of gold coinage (dropping from 98% to below 60% purity) signal to economic historians?

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| (A) An era of unprecedented fiscal expansion and surging treasury reserves | (B) Economic decline, fiscal distress, and contraction of long-distance trade |
| (C) An intentional artistic decision to make coins look darker | (D) A total lack of consumer interest in trading goods |

Q.14 Which geographic trade corridor was controlled by the Kushanas, facilitating their massive economic prosperity?

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| (A) The Trans-Saharan salt trade route in North Africa | (B) The Silk Route overland trading network across Central and South Asia |
| (C) The Atlantic triangular slave trade corridor | (D) The Baltic Amber maritime shipping route |

Q.15 How do numismatic discoveries assist historians in mapping the territorial borders of ancient empires?

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| (A) Coins are only found buried inside the personal bedroom of the ruling king | (B) The geographic spatial distribution of regular coin hoards outlines active administrative and commercial zones |
| (C) Coins contain detailed printed street maps of the entire empire | (D) Coins dissolve immediately when taken outside the sovereign borders |

CASE STUDY 4: METHODOLOGICAL TRIANGULATION IN SOCIAL SCIENCE RESEARCH

A sociological research team set out to investigate the impact of women's self-help groups (SHGs) on household decision-making in rural Maharashtra. To ensure methodological rigor, the researchers adopted a mixed-methods design combining quantitative and qualitative tools. First, they administered a structured sample survey across 500 households, generating statistical tables on micro-credit repayment rates, girl child school enrollment, and nutritional budgets. However, acknowledging that survey questionnaires can suffer from social desirability bias (where respondents give answers they believe the interviewer wants to hear), the team also conducted in-depth qualitative semi-structured interviews and participatory rural appraisals (PRA). They cross-verified household survey claims against bank passbooks, panchayat meeting attendance registers, and local health clinic records. By triangulating data from multiple independent sources, the researchers minimized researcher subjectivity and constructed an empirically grounded, nuanced analysis of grassroots rural empowerment.

Q.16 What does the concept of 'methodological triangulation' mean in social science research?

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| (A) Drawing geometric triangles on topographic maps | (B) Cross-checking findings using multiple independent research methods and data sources |
| (C) Surveying exactly three individuals in every rural village | (D) Rejecting all empirical facts in favor of personal theoretical opinions |

Q.17 What is 'social desirability bias' in quantitative survey research?

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|---|---|
| (A) When respondents intentionally distort answers to appear socially approved or favorable | (B) When survey forms are printed on expensive high-quality paper |
| (C) When everyone in a village refuses to answer any survey question | (D) When researchers calculate mathematical averages incorrectly |

Q.18 Why did the researchers verify verbal interview claims against bank passbooks and panchayat registers?

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| (A) To confiscate the villagers' money and public funds | (B) To obtain objective material documentary evidence that corroborates or challenges verbal claims |
| (C) To prove that written documents are always fake and unreliable | (D) To teach villagers how to sign their names |

Q.19 Which data collection tool utilized in this study provides quantitative statistical metrics?

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| (A) Open-ended personal oral storytelling | (B) A structured questionnaire survey across 500 households |
| (C) Observing village festivals without taking notes | (D) Reading ancient folk tales about village history |

Q.20 Why is interdisciplinary integration between sociology and economics beneficial when studying women's empowerment?

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| <p>(A) It confuses researchers by forcing them to study two unrelated topics</p> <p>(C) Sociology and economics use completely identical mathematical formulas for every problem</p> | <p>(B) Economic data on micro-credit financial flows directly interacts with sociological patterns of household authority and gender roles</p> <p>(D) It allows researchers to avoid doing any field interviews</p> |
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CASE STUDY 5: DEMOCRATIC VALUES, CRITICAL PEDAGOGY, AND CIVIC EDUCATION

The National Curriculum Framework (NCF) emphasizes that the primary purpose of social science education at the secondary stage is not mere rote memorization of historical dates or administrative lists, but the cultivation of critical thinking, constitutional literacy, and democratic values. A classroom in Pune engaged students in analyzing real-world municipal solid waste management policies. Rather than lecturing from a textbook, the teacher divided students into groups representing diverse stakeholders: municipal sanitation workers demanding safety gear and dignified wages, middle-class residents protesting landfills near their homes, informal scrap-dealers (kabadiwalas) recycling plastic waste, and urban planners balancing municipal budgets. Through structured deliberation, students learned to negotiate trade-offs, recognize structural inequalities, evaluate evidence, and practice mutual respect for competing social interests, reflecting the living spirit of constitutional democracy.

Q.21 What is the primary pedagogical goal of social science education according to modern CBSE curriculum frameworks?

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| <p>(A) Memorizing chronological dynasties and regurgitating them on demand</p> <p>(C) Accepting all government policies uncritically without question</p> | <p>(B) Developing critical inquiry, constitutional values, and evidence-based analytical reasoning</p> <p>(D) Training students to avoid all civic participation in public life</p> |
|---|---|

Q.22 How does the multi-stakeholder role-play exercise assist students in understanding democratic decision-making?

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| <p>(A) It shows that only one single group in society has valid interests</p> <p>(C) It teaches students that the richest group should always dictate government decisions</p> | <p>(B) It demonstrates that democratic policies require balancing competing legitimate interests through peaceful negotiation and compromise</p> <p>(D) It proves that urban planners never need to consult local citizens</p> |
|--|--|

Q.23 Recognizing the vital contributions of informal waste recyclers (kabadiwalas) highlights which core democratic principle?

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| <p>(A) Authoritarian social hierarchy</p> <p>(C) Aristocratic privilege based on birth</p> | <p>(B) Dignity of labour and recognition of marginalized economic contributors</p> <p>(D) Exclusion of informal workers from public welfare programs</p> |
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Q.24 Critical inquiry in social sciences requires students to:

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| <p>(A) Reject all factual data and believe arbitrary rumors</p> <p>(C) Refuse to listen to people with differing viewpoints</p> | <p>(B) Evaluate the validity, reliability, and potential biases of different sources of information</p> <p>(D) Accept whatever appears on social media as absolute truth</p> |
|---|--|

Q.25 How does constitutional literacy empower citizens in a democratic republic?

- (A) It enables citizens to understand their fundamental rights and hold public institutions accountable to the rule of law
- (B) It grants politicians absolute immunity from judicial review
- (C) It ensures that elections are held only once every fifty years
- (D) It eliminates the need for independent courts and news media

CBSE CANDIDATE OMR ANSWER RESPONSE GRID (SET E)

01	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	02	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	03	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	04	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	05	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D
06	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	07	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	08	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	09	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	10	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D
11	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	12	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	13	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	14	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	15	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D
16	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	17	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	18	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	19	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	20	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D
21	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	22	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	23	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	24	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D	25	☐ A ☐ B ☐ C ☐ D

Total Questions Attempted: ____ / 25

Marks Obtained: ____ / 25

Evaluator's Signature: _____

OFFICIAL ANSWER KEY & CASE STUDY ANALYTICAL EXPLANATIONS (SET E)

Q. No.	Correct	Curricular Source Analysis & Conceptual Explanation
Q.1	(D)	Under the Law of Superposition, lower undisturbed sedimentary strata are deposited earlier in time than overlying layers. Stratum IV, being deepest, is the oldest.
Q.2	(B)	Stratigraphic balks preserve vertical earth walls displaying continuous cross-sectional profiles, allowing correlation of soil layers across excavation squares.
Q.3	(B)	Bilingual coinage with Greek and Kharosthi scripts reflects the confluence of Hellenistic-Bactrian and indigenous Indian traditions in the northwest.
Q.4	(B)	Burnt cultural horizons containing projectile points like arrowheads are diagnostic material signatures of warfare and destructive conquest.
Q.5	(A)	Primary historical sources are original material artifacts or records created contemporaneously during the exact historical era being investigated.
Q.6	(B)	Prinsep used bilingual coins where known Greek royal names matched phonetic Brahmi equivalents, unlocking the alphabet's phonetic key.
Q.7	(B)	Epigraphy is the branch of historical science dealing with the study, reading, and decipherment of inscriptions.
Q.8	(B)	Inscribing royal edicts along prominent trade highways ensured maximum civic exposure for Ashoka's ethical messages of tolerance and social welfare.
Q.9	(A)	Minor Rock Edicts at Maski (Karnataka) and Gurjarra (Madhya Pradesh) explicitly pair the epithet 'Devanampiya' directly with the personal name 'Ashoka'.
Q.10	(C)	Ashoka's Dhamma championed humanitarian welfare, non-violence (ahimsa), medical clinics for all beings, and universal social harmony.
Q.11	(B)	High gold purity and uniform mass standards in coinage reflect an affluent state treasury supported by flourishing transnational commerce.
Q.12	(B)	Roman gold flowed into India to balance the trade deficit caused by high Roman consumer demand for Malabar pepper, silks, and gemstones.
Q.13	(B)	Currency debasement occurs when cash-strapped governments dilute precious metal content due to depleted reserves and declining commercial revenue.
Q.14	(B)	The Kushana Empire straddled vital junctions of the Central Asian Silk Route connecting China, India, Parthia, and Rome.
Q.15	(B)	Mapping the geographic density and dispersal of coin finds reveals the commercial and administrative reach of the issuing sovereign.
Q.16	(B)	Triangulation is the technique of validating findings by combining multiple independent quantitative and qualitative data sources to cancel out biases.
Q.17	(A)	Social desirability bias occurs when respondents report behaviors they view as socially prestigious or expected rather than their actual practices.
Q.18	(B)	Institutional registers and financial passbooks provide verifiable primary documentary checks against self-reported verbal accounts.
Q.19	(B)	Structured sample surveys with standardized numerical questions produce quantitative data amenable to statistical aggregation.

Q. No.	Correct	Curricular Source Analysis & Conceptual Explanation
Q.20	(B)	Socioeconomic realities cannot be understood in silos; financial mechanisms (economics) directly influence gender power relations (sociology).
Q.21	(B)	Modern social science pedagogy aims to develop critical discernment, civic agency, empathy, and active constitutional citizenship.
Q.22	(B)	Democratic governance is fundamentally about negotiating accommodation among pluralistic, competing legitimate interests within a constitutional framework.
Q.23	(B)	Valuing informal sector workers fosters democratic equality, human dignity, and social justice as envisioned in the Constitution.
Q.24	(B)	Critical inquiry involves examining evidence, questioning assumptions, identifying biases, and reasoning logically from reliable data.
Q.25	(A)	Constitutional literacy enables people to claim rights, fulfill civic duties, and ensure public authorities adhere to constitutional limits.